other's games. Unfortunately, AB's message was something of a jinx – Smithy went out the very next ball.

Does this make for a clique? Look, it's inevitable that members of an international team will form close bonds. It's what happens when a bunch of guys go to war together. And, make no mistake, international cricket is a war. I guess people have a problem with this when one of the guys in this circle of tight friends is the team captain. There's a perception that it splits the team into 'us' and 'them'.

Other international players have quizzed me on this. One of the benefits of socialising with other international players in the IPL is that you get to hear what they think of the Proteas. One consistent observation has been their surprise at seeing Smith, Bouch and Kallis, in particular, always going out together. I understand where they are coming from but, as I said, war forges close bonds and it's only human nature that Graeme is going to form close ties with his lieutenants.

This is a weird situation for me, because I've always kept myself in the middle, and I'm equally comfortable both in- and outside this group. I can hang out with both Bouch and Makhaya – that's just the sort of person I am. Bouch, for example, has been a really good friend to me over the years and offered me support and valuable advice. He's been a great servant to South African cricket, and his opinion and experience are respected within the team.

With regard to being able to fit in easily, I think JP Duminy is a lot like me … but I know some players have found it a complicated situation. Perhaps it's a cultural issue, but I can't know for sure. Whatever the reason is, I do think we still have some work ahead of us to build a stronger overall bond within the Proteas.

Obviously there's only one person ultimately responsible for building a unified team, and that's the captain. Graeme is a powerful presence, and his personality is one that almost insists on being a leader. There's also no questioning the guy's courage on the field and his willingness to stand up and take the flak for us when we're under public scrutiny. Given all this, is it a justifiable criticism to say he has got too close to certain players?

Perhaps you might think so, but I have played under enough guys to know what a tough job Graeme has. Plus, I am confident in the knowledge that I'm not a captain's arse. As I've said, I had known from my school days – when there's always pressure on the best player to be captain – that I was